



KEY

1 The central light emanates from the Hebrew Tetragrammaton "YHWH," letters important in Kabbalah to represent God.

2 Light rays emanate from the figure representing day, and bounce off the mirror.

3 The title means "The Great Art of Light and Shade." In a play on words, "magna" could be translated to mean "magnetic" instead of "great."

4 The figure of night is clothed in stars.

5 The double-headed eagle is a symbol of Kircher's patron, Ferdinand II.

► Decoding the divine

The title page taken from Athanasius Kircher's work *Ars magna lucis et umbræ* (1646) interweaves the science of optics with esoterica and features kabbalistic symbolism.

